Title: Former Bank CFO Sentenced to 36 Months' Imprisonment for Bank Fraud Scheme Involving a Car Wash and Undisclosed Debts in $4.3 Million Loan Fraud
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United States Attorney Lesley A. Woods announced that Aaron T. Luneke, 44, of Columbus, Nebraska, was sentenced on July 13, 2026, in federal court in Omaha, Nebraska, after being convicted by a federal jury of committing bank fraud and attempted bank fraud in connection with loans he sought to build and operate a Legacy Express Wash, a car wash in Columbus. United States District Brian C. Buescher sentenced Luneke to 36 months' imprisonment. There is no parole in the federal system. After his release from prison, Luneke will begin a five-year term of supervised release. Judge Buescher ordered Luneke to pay a $10,000 fine.

The jury found that Luneke attempted to defraud Stearns Bank, located in St. Cloud, Minnesota, by using fraudulent and inflated contractor invoices to artificially inflate the valuation of the car wash property in pursuit of a $3.5 million refinancing loan. Further evidence at trial established that Luneke failed to disclose significant personal debts owed to family members in connection with the Stearns Bank loan application. The jury also found that Luneke defrauded Bank of the Valley by submitting fraudulent and inflated invoices from contractors as the basis for additional construction loan proceeds, obtaining two loans totaling approximately $4,320,000.

At the sentencing, Judge Buescher found that Luneke's abuse of his position as Chief Financial Officer at Bank of the Valley significantly facilitated the commission and concealment of the fraud against the victim bank. The Court further determined that Luneke employed sophisticated means to carry out the scheme; served an aggravating role by organizing, leading, managing, or supervising others in executing aspects of the fraud; obstructed justice by providing false testimony during trial; and caused a victim to suffer substantial financial hardship.

The case was investigated by the Federal Bureau of Investigation, Omaha Field Office; the Federal Deposit Insurance Corporation, Office of Inspector General; the Federal Housing Finance Agency, Office of Inspector General; and the Board of Governors of the Federal Reserve System, Office of Inspector General.

The case was investigated and prosecuted by Assistant United States Attorneys Sean Lynch and Sarah Hinrichs and tried with the assistance of Special Assistant United States Attorney Alejandro A. Abreu.